Story: Turning Around a Slipping Team (Moderna Data Engineering)

Practice date: 2026-10-20. Prompt: "Tell me about a time you inherited or led a team whose performance had slipped. How did you diagnose the real causes, and what did you do to turn it around without simply replacing people?"

The story in Shridhar's words (facts)

Eight-person data engineering team at Moderna. Moderna was reorganizing from central teams (central data, central data science, central software) to distributed ones. The team's poster-child project, the individualized neoantigen therapy (INT) platform, moved to another team, while Shridhar's team kept maintenance responsibility for six months and owned a smooth transition.

Within one quarter, two committed milestones slipped: a move to a new stack was missed, and an upgrade project ran two months against a one-month plan. Shridhar spent roughly two weeks in one-on-ones with team members and with business partners, asking what was not working and how the team itself would fix it.

The diagnosis: it was not skill. The team had built the INT system and was emotionally attached to it. They did not trust the receiving team to maintain it well. And they had no visibility into what their own next projects would be. The system had treated people and work as transferable objects, with no account of how emotions actually work.

Actions:

- Created a forum giving the team visibility into the real, interesting projects coming to them.
- Brought the receiving team into the fold: joint rituals, weekly meetings together, design reviews in both directions - the handover became joint work rather than a throw over the wall.
- Joint goals across both teams, aligned to Moderna-wide goals rather than one team's goals.
- 30-day plan: build trust. 60-day plan: measurable goals, new build work to create momentum, structured handover tracking.
- Culture change, made permanent: in future transitions, engineering and business partners are part of the planning from day one. Nobody gets handed a finished decision.

Outcomes:

- The handover completed on the six-month timeline. Everything that was supposed to transfer transferred. The system has run smoothly for almost a year since, and the two teams still help each other occasionally.
- Two of the eight engineers joined the receiving team because they loved that project - the work kept its experts.
- One engineer never re-engaged with transition work. Over three months, despite constant feedback, he disrupted meetings and did not come around. Shridhar moved him off the transition project onto a fresh build project - his strength is building, not transitioning - with a coaching plan on the transition-fit issue. He is still on that coaching plan.

What went well in the mock

- The diagnosis is the heart of this prompt and it landed: three distinct fears (grief over losing the project, distrust the receiving team would maintain it well, no visible future work), each with a different fix. Most candidates never get past "morale was low."
- The people outcomes demonstrate the "turn it around without replacing people" requirement instead of just claiming it: two engineers followed the work, one was redeployed to his strength with a coaching plan, nobody was exited.

- The permanent culture change (partners in the room from day one) closes the loop with a systemic fix, not just a one-time rescue.

What went wrong in the mock

- Delivery meandered. The headline - eight-person team, two slipped milestones in one quarter, cause was grief and distrust - took minutes to assemble, and the load-bearing numbers (8 people, upgrade at two months vs one planned, six-month handover, a year of stability) only surfaced under probing. An interviewer will not probe that patiently. Open with the stakes.
- "He is still on a coaching plan" sounds unresolved when said flat. Name what the plan targets (fit for transition-type work) and what the engineer is doing now (building), so it reads as a managed decision rather than a loose end.
- The Result arrived last and thinnest. In the real answer, the six-month completion and the year of stability belong up front in the headline, not at the end as an afterthought.

The ideal answer (~2.5 minutes spoken)

"Eight-person data engineering team at Moderna. In one quarter we slipped two committed milestones - a move to a new stack, and an upgrade that ran two months against a one-month plan. The cause was not skill. It was grief and distrust.

Moderna was reorganizing from central teams to distributed ones, and our poster-child project, the individualized neoantigen therapy platform, was moving to another team. We kept maintenance responsibility for six months. On paper that is a clean handover. In practice the team had built that system, did not trust the receiving team to maintain it well, and had no idea what their own next project was. Delivery slipped because nobody had named any of that.

I spent two weeks in one-on-ones with the team and with our business partners before I changed anything. The first 30 days were trust work. I created a forum where the team could see the real projects coming to us, so the future was visible. I brought the receiving team into our weekly rituals and our design reviews, and we went into theirs - the handover stopped being a throw over the wall and became joint work, with joint goals. The next 60 days added measurable goals: new build work to create momentum, and a structured transfer plan we tracked together.

Two of my eight engineers ultimately joined the receiving team, because they loved that project, and I count that as the healthiest outcome on the table - the work kept its experts. One engineer never re-engaged with transition work despite direct feedback over three months. His strength is building new things, so I moved him to a greenfield project and put the transition-fit issue on a coaching plan rather than forcing a fit that was not there.

The handover completed on the six-month timeline. The system has run smoothly for a year since, and the two teams still help each other. What I changed permanently: in any later transition, the engineering and business partners are in the room from day one. Nobody on my team gets handed a finished decision again."

Likely follow-ups, with the honest answers

- "How did you measure the turnaround at 90 days?" - "Milestone delivery resumed against the joint plan, and the handover checklist we tracked with the receiving team stayed green. The real proof came at six months: everything transferred, on time, and the system has been stable for a year since."
- "Really - nobody had to go?" - "Nobody was exited. Two chose to follow the project to the receiving team. One moved to work that matched his strength, with a coaching plan on the gap. Replacing people would have been faster. It also would have thrown away the trust the fix was built on."

- "What if the receiving team had refused to join your rituals?" - "That was the risk in the first two weeks. The lever was joint goals tied to Moderna-level outcomes, not my team's convenience - both teams were measured on the same transition succeeding."